

Cables And Manuals

The Asus, Samsung and Sony were the only drives that shipped with data cables. With the other drives, you'll need to purchase the cable separately. Only the Sony drive came with a printed manual, whereas the others came with just quick-start guides. Of course, you can always download the manual from the manufacturer's Web site, but a printed manual is always preferable!

Bundled Media

Most of the drive manufacturers decided not to bundle blank media with the drives. Surprisingly, the Lite-On drives, the lowest-priced ones, came with blank media. The BenQ DW1625 and the Lite-On Super AllWrite even shipped with a LightScribe CD!

Bundled Software

The Asus DRW-1608P2S came with Ulead DVD MovieFactory 4 Disc Creator, a very good video creating and editing software.

The Plextor PX-716A, which comes under the Premium range, came with the famed PlexTools Professional, which allow you to tweak the drive's features—such as maximum read and write speeds—to suit your needs. It also featured GigaRec—a technology that allows you to write up to 1 GB of data to CD.

Performance

Speeds And Access Times

In the Nero CD-DVD Speed Test, the Plextor PX-740A logged the highest read speeds for a DVD at an average speed of 12x. The highest burst speed was logged by the other Plextor, the PX-716A, at 42 MBps. Copying data from these drives will be faster than from other drives.

In the SiSoft Sandra test, once again, the Plextor PX-740A logged the highest score in the data transfer test. The Lite-On LightScribe SHW-16H5S logged the lowest access time, which means it is the fastest in accessing data on the media. A fast access time means you can search faster on a CD or DVD, and navigate videos with better responsiveness.

Audio CDs

Audio CD ripping times were more or less the same across the drives, except that the Samsung and the Plextor PX-716A proved

to be much slower. We repeated the tests several times and got the same results every time. For reasons unknown, the Plextor, which is otherwise a fast reader, is somewhat slow when it comes to reading audio CDs.

DVD Ripping

In these tests, too, the Plextor PX-716A lagged behind the others, being slower by a factor of two. The LG drive was also almost as slow as the Plextor in ripping DVD movies. If DVD ripping is slow on a drive, DVD playback is bound to suffer.

CD-R Writing

The Plextor PX-716A was slow in some cases, fast in others—for example, in the CD-R writing test, it was the fastest. The Giga-byte GO-W1623A, which is supposed to be able to write at 48x, could write only at 16x—and hence logged the lowest scores. However, when we tried writing to another brand of media, the problem disappeared, and it was able to write at 48x. This points to a compatibility issue.

DVD-R Writing

The LG was the fastest here, followed closely by the Asus. There was not much variation in the writing speeds of the rest of the drives, with the exception of the BenQ DW1640, which took almost twice the time to finish writing the assorted DVD-R.

DVD+R Writing

We found that both the Asus and the Plextor PX-716A could write at 12x to the 8x DVD+R media we had, and they did so without a flaw! This is possible because of the drive's over-speed burning capabilities, meaning it can write to media at speeds faster than the media's rated speed.

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The Plextor was the faster of the two. The fact that these drives offer over-speed writing out-of-the-box for DVD+R, without producing coasters, is a feat in itself.

In Conclusion

Features and performance have been taken into account earlier on in the tests, but the price factor decided the winner.

The Lite-On LightScribe SHW-16H5S was unique, with its LightScribe capability. It came with a LightScribe CD along with blank DVD+R and DVD-R media. Its performance was also better than that of most drives, and it is priced at Rs 3,975—which is very good for a LightScribe drive. We therefore awarded the Lite-On LightScribe SHW-16H5S the Digit Best Buy Silver.

The Lite-On Super AllWrite SHM-165P6S is a multi-drive. It is capable of writing to dual-layer media at 8x, which is the fastest in its class. It came with blank DVDs and a silver as well as a black bezel so you can change the bezel to match the colour of your PC's cabinet. To top it all, it was the best performer, and is priced at Rs 3,085, which is dirt cheap for a multi-drive with top-notch performance. The Lite-On Super AllWrite SHM-165P6S therefore gets a well-deserved Digit Best Buy Gold.

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EXTERNAL DVD-WRITERS

External DVD-Writers connect to a PC either via USB 2.0 or FireWire (IEEE 1394) or both. These are plug-and-play devices, and so do not need the PC to be shut down before they can be plugged in. Also, they need an external power supply, and ship with an AC adapter.

Like we've mentioned, external DVD-Writers are not as popular with the average home user because they cost a lot more than their internal counterparts,